But this humble approach made little headway, and the Cathars continued to flourish.

Meanwhile, the official representatives of the pope were experiencing the same lack of success. Finding the Cathars themselves deaf to their preaching, they traveled to Toulouse and demanded a meeting with Raymond VI, the Count of Toulouse, the overlord of Languedoc.

Raymond VI, himself an orthodox Christian, was one of the powerful noblemen who had long ringed the land of the king of France and restricted his power. He was inclined to act as independently as possible. When the legates arrived and insisted on seeing him, they ordered him imperiously to take action against the heretics in his land; Raymond, set on edge by the abrasive assumption of authority, refused to listen.

At this, one of the legates, Pierre de Castelnau, summarily excommunicated him. This brought any discussion to an immediate end. Raymond dismissed the legates brusquely and shut his gates against them.

William of Tudela, who knew all the parties involved and wrote his own account of the events that followed, tells us that as the legates traveled back northwards, "an evil-hearted squire, hoping to win the count's approval, stepped like a traitor behind the legate, drove his sharp sword into his spine, and killed him. . . . You can be sure that the pope was not pleased."[9]

He was, in fact, furious. No one accused Raymond himself of involvement, but Raymond certainly expressed no sorrow over Pierre de Castelnau's death. The growing ecclesiastical problem had now been joined by a political one.

Thanks to the resurrection of the crusading impulse, Innocent III had a solution to hand. He declared a crusade—not just against the Cathars but against the orthodox Raymond as well. All of Raymond's subjects were absolved from their obedience to him; anyone who took up the sword against the Count of Toulouse would be given absolution of sin and all the privileges awarded to Crusaders who had made the long, dangerous journey to Jerusalem; and anyone who took wealth or property away from a Cathar could keep it.[10]

Once again, the idea of *crusade* had expanded. For the Wendish Crusade against the Slavic tribes in northern Germany, it had been puffed into a size that could accommodate war against non-Christians living in Christian lands. Now it was distended further, to encompass not only unorthodox Christians but a thoroughly orthodox brother whose only offense was his refusal to take political commands from Rome.

In the past, the pope had used spiritual weapons—excommunication and interdict—to face such defiance. Now the sword of crusade was added to his